low-cost, short-range wireless networking standard that enables you to establish PANs. The earlier 1.2 version offered speeds of about 700 Kbps, but the current 2.0 version offers speeds of up to 2.1 Mbps. Bluetooth 2.0 operates on the 5 GHz frequency (2.4 GHz for the original Bluetooth standard), and has a range of just 10 metres (33 feet). In terms of home networking, Bluetooth has nothing much to offer. However, when looking for a cheap and neat alternative to the messy wires that connect various immobile devices together, such as a printer and scanner connecting to a PC, Bluetooth is the answer.

Bluetooth is mainly used in mobile devices such as cell phones, PDAs and laptops as a means of short-range data transfer, such as when syncing the PDA with a PC or laptop, or using a Bluetooth headset with your mobile phone, so that you never have to take the phone out of your pocket to answer a call. Though the speeds offered are a fraction of what Wi-Fi has to offer, the significantly lower power consumption of Bluetooth chips more than makes up for it. The fact that battery technologies for mobile devices are lagging far behind all other technologies in the same field has helped Bluetooth gain a stranglehold on the mobile device market—after all, what good is a Wi-Fi cell phone that transfers data at speeds in excess of 20 Mbps, but whose battery lasts only 5 minutes?

In the near future, Bluetooth 2.0 should soon become the solution to the clumsy and cluttered wires that connect our devices, such as keyboards and mice to PCs, and printers or scanners in small LANs. Already, you can use most new phones with Bluetooth to connect to laptops and PDAs in order to connect to the Internet.

Home networking doesn't necessarily have to be wireless, as the next two technologies will prove.

HPNA

Short for Home Phoneline Networking Alliance, this solution is based on the assumption that you have a phone line in your house. Most modern houses have internal phone wiring with outlets in